

Perspectives

Character & Grammar Through Stories

Episode 4 – The Burnout

Level: B2–C1 (IELTS Band 6.5–8.0)

Student Name: _____

Date: _____

Level: B2–C1

Learning Goals

- ✓ Read and interpret a discursive, opinion-based story
- ✓ Form mixed conditionals (past condition/present result, and vice versa)
- ✓ Use inversion in conditionals: Had..., Were it not for..., Should...
- ✓ Acquire an extended set of Academic Word List vocabulary and collocations
- ✓ Practise IELTS-style sentence transformation and error correction
- ✓ Produce an IELTS Task 2-style discursive paragraph
- ✓ Reflect critically on workload, boundaries, and workplace culture

SECTION 1 | WARM-UP — Before You Read

Part A — Prediction & Opinion Questions

Instructions: These questions require you to take a position, not just guess a plot. Answer before reading.

1. To what extent do you agree that preventing burnout is primarily the individual employee's responsibility, rather than the employer's?

2. Some people believe that admitting 'I have too much work' makes an employee look less capable. To what extent do you agree?

Part B — Personal Reflection

Instructions: Answer honestly from your own experience or context.

1. Have you ever taken on more work or responsibility than you could comfortably manage? What happened?

2. What signs, in yourself or in someone close to you, usually show that a workload has become too heavy?

SECTION 2 | MAIN STORY — Read the Story

Instructions: Read the story carefully. Underline every mixed conditional, and circle every inverted conditional (Had..., Were it not for..., Should...).

The Burnout

Rakib had been at the agency for eleven months, working at a pace he privately suspected was unsustainable, and for almost all of that time he had operated by a private rule: if the work needed doing, he did it, regardless of what it cost him elsewhere. He told himself this was simply what a first job required — a phase, not a pattern.

Lately, the pattern had started to show. He forgot deadlines he had noted a week earlier; a client's brand name he had typed correctly a hundred times appeared, one exhausted night, entirely misspelled in a report. If he had raised the issue weeks ago, he probably wouldn't be this exhausted now — a thought that arrived, unhelpfully, close to midnight. The long nights were taking a toll on more than just his sleep, and his workload had quietly tripled since his first month, without anyone officially deciding it should.

Had he mentioned it to his manager three months earlier, some of it would probably have been redistributed. He hadn't. At the time, saying "I have too much" had felt like admitting he was incapable — an outcome that, to him, seemed worse than exhaustion itself.

His colleague Nasrin, who had joined the agency two years before him, found him one evening still at his desk long after most of the office had emptied. "You're here late again," she said, not as a question.

"Just finishing something," Rakib said, not looking up.

"You said that yesterday. And the day before." She pulled a chair over. "If you keep burning the candle at both ends like this, you're not going to burn out gradually. You'll hit a wall all at once, and it will take you far longer to recover than it took to run yourself into the ground."

Rakib gave a tired laugh. "I don't really have a choice. If I don't finish this tonight, the client presentation tomorrow won't be ready."

"Would it really fall apart if you handed over half of it tonight and finished the rest fresh in the morning?" Nasrin asked. "Or does it just feel unmanageable because you're too exhausted to see the difference?"

He didn't answer immediately.

"I went through this in my second year," Nasrin said. "Were it not for a friend who physically took my laptop away one Friday night, I probably would have kept going until I made a genuinely serious mistake, not just a typo. If I weren't so stubborn back then, I would have asked for help long before I actually reached breaking point. You do bounce back from one bad week. You don't bounce back as easily from months of this."

"So what did you do?" Rakib asked.

"I started speaking up, out loud, when I had too much. Not dramatically — just factually. 'I can take this, but something else will slip.' It felt like weakness the first few times. It wasn't. It was information my manager needed and simply didn't have, because nobody had told him."

Rakib looked at his screen, then closed the laptop halfway. “If I tell him tomorrow that the projections need another day, what happens?”

“Honestly? Probably nothing dramatic. Should the situation actually go badly, it would already have happened to someone else on this team by now — and it hasn’t.” Nasrin stood up. “Go home tonight. Finish it in daylight, rested. See if it’s actually different.”

Rakib packed his bag, still uncertain but noticeably lighter than he had felt in weeks. The presentation, finished the next morning, was not obviously better or worse than it would have been the night before — he genuinely couldn’t tell. What was different was that he had slept, and that, for the first time in months, he had said a true sentence about his workload out loud, to someone who could actually do something about it.

He didn’t leave the agency any earlier the following week. The deadlines hadn’t changed, and neither, really, had the culture that produced them. But he had started keeping a private note of what he said yes to, and had begun, slowly, learning to delegate what he could and decline what he couldn’t manage. Whether that would be enough to build any real resilience months from now, he genuinely didn’t know. Nasrin didn’t pretend to know either. All she had offered, in the end, was proof that someone else had survived the same pattern he was still learning to break.

SECTION 3 | VOCABULARY ZONE

Instructions: Study the words and collocations below. Take your time with this extended list, and revisit it after reading the story.

Word / Phrase	Part of Speech	Simple English Meaning	বাংলা অর্থ
burnout	noun	a state of physical or mental exhaustion caused by prolonged stress	কর্মক্লান্তি
exhausted	adjective	extremely tired	চরম ক্লান্ত
workload	noun	the amount of work someone has to do	কাজের চাপ
redistribute	verb	to share something out again in a different way	পুনর্বণ্টন করা
boundaries	noun (pl.)	limits that protect a person's time and energy	সীমারেখা
overwhelmed	adjective	having too much to deal with at once	অভিভূত
manageable	adjective	able to be dealt with reasonably	সামলানো সম্ভব এমন
recover	verb	to return to a normal, healthy state	সেরে ওঠা
resilience	noun	the ability to recover from difficulty	সহনশীলতা / ঘুরে দাঁড়ানোর ক্ষমতা
capable	adjective	able to do something well	সক্ষম
incapable	adjective	not able to do something	অক্ষম
delegate	verb	to give a task to someone else to complete	দায়িত্ব অর্পণ করা
unsustainable	adjective	not able to continue at the same level for long	অস্থায়ী / টিকিয়ে রাখা যায় না এমন
pace	noun	the speed at which something happens	গতি
toll	noun	a serious harmful effect that builds up over time	ক্ষতির পরিমাণ
take a toll on	phrase	to have a harmful effect on someone over time	ধীরে ধীরে ক্ষতি করা
burn the candle at both ends	phrase	to work excessively without enough rest	অতিরিক্ত পরিশ্রম করে বিশ্রামহীন থাকা
reach breaking point	phrase	to arrive at a point where one can no longer cope	সহ্যসীমা ছাড়িয়ে যাওয়া
bounce back	phrasal verb	to recover quickly from a difficulty	দ্রুত সেরে ওঠা
run oneself into the ground	phrase	to make oneself ill or exhausted through overwork	নিজেকে নিঃশেষ করে ফেলা
hit a wall	phrase	to reach a point where one cannot continue or progress	আর এগোতে না পারার অবস্থা

Word / Phrase	Part of Speech	Simple English Meaning	বাংলা অর্থ
speak up	phrasal verb	to express a concern or opinion openly	সরবে বলা / প্রকাশ করা

Task A — Matching

Instructions: Match each word with its correct meaning. Write the letter in the Your Answer column.

Word	Your Answer
1. burnout	_____
2. boundaries	_____
3. resilience	_____
4. delegate	_____
5. unsustainable	_____
6. toll	_____
7. incapable	_____
8. manageable	_____

- A. a state of exhaustion caused by prolonged stress
- B. limits that protect a person's time and energy
- C. the ability to recover from difficulty
- D. to give a task to someone else to complete
- E. not able to continue at the same level for long
- F. a serious harmful effect that builds up over time
- G. not able to do something
- H. able to be dealt with reasonably

Task B — Fill in the Blanks

Instructions: Choose the best word or phrase from the box and complete the sentences.

Word Box: workload | redistribute | overwhelmed | recover | pace | take a toll on | hit a wall

- Rakib's _____ had quietly tripled since his first month at the agency.
- Had he spoken up sooner, some of his tasks might have been _____ among the team.
- By the time Nasrin found him, Rakib looked completely _____ by his responsibilities.
- Sleeping properly gave Rakib at least a small chance to _____.
- Nasrin warned Rakib that his current _____ of work was not something he could sustain for long.
- Months of late nights had begun to _____ his concentration.
- Nasrin explained that ignoring the warning signs eventually makes a person _____ completely.

Task C — Vocabulary in Context

Instructions: Read each quotation from the story and guess the meaning of the underlined word or phrase from context.

1. "Rakib had been at the agency for eleven months, working at a pace he privately suspected was unsustainable." What does unsustainable suggest about the pace?

2. "The long nights were taking a toll on more than just his sleep." What does taking a toll on mean here?

3. "If you keep burning the candle at both ends like this, you're not going to burn out gradually." What does burning the candle at both ends mean?

4. "You'll hit a wall all at once." What does hit a wall mean in this context?

5. "I would have asked for help long before I actually reached breaking point." What does reached breaking point mean?

6. "You do bounce back from one bad week. You don't bounce back as easily from months of this." What does bounce back mean here?

Task D — Personal Vocabulary Journal

Instructions: Choose 4 new words or phrases from this episode. Write the Bangla meaning and your own English sentence.

No.	New Word/Phrase	বাংলা অর্থ	My Own English Sentence
1			
2			
3			
4			

SECTION 4 | GRAMMAR DETECTIVE 🔍 — Mixed Conditionals & Inversion

Task A — Find from the Story

Instructions: Find and copy the required number of examples for each grammar focus from the story.

Grammar Focus	Examples from the Story
2 Mixed Conditionals (past condition → present result)	_____
2 Mixed Conditionals (general/past trait → past result)	_____
2 Inversion with 'Had' (no if)	_____
1 Inversion with 'Were it not for'	_____
1 Inversion with 'Should'	_____

Task B — Grammar Lab

Instructions: For each sentence, identify the structure, explain why it is used, and write a similar sentence of your own.

1. *"If he had raised the issue weeks ago, he probably wouldn't be this exhausted now."*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

2. *"If I weren't so stubborn back then, I would have asked for help long before I actually reached breaking point."*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

3. *"Had he mentioned it to his manager three months earlier, some of it would probably have been redistributed."*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

4. *"Were it not for a friend who physically took my laptop away one Friday night, I probably would have kept going."*

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

5. "Should the situation actually go badly, it would already have happened to someone else on this team by now."

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

6. "If I don't finish this tonight, the client presentation tomorrow won't be ready." (compare: a real, first-conditional warning)

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

SECTION 5 | MIXED GRAMMAR CHALLENGE

A — Error Correction

Instructions: Each sentence contains one error in a mixed conditional or an inverted conditional. Rewrite it correctly.

1. If he raised the issue weeks ago, he wouldn't be this exhausted now.

2. If I wasn't so stubborn back then, I would have asked for help sooner.

3. Had he mention it to his manager, some of it would have been redistributed.

4. Were it not for a friend, I would kept going until I made a mistake.

5. Should the situation go badly, it already happen to someone else.

6. If he had asked for help, he isn't this exhausted now.

B — Multiple Choice

Instructions: Choose the best answer: A, B, C, or D.

1. If he _____ the issue weeks ago, he wouldn't be this exhausted now.

A. raises B. had raised C. raised D. has raised Answer: _____

2. If I weren't so stubborn, I _____ for help months ago.

A. would ask B. would have asked C. will ask D. asked Answer: _____

3. _____ he mentioned it earlier, some of it would have been redistributed.

A. If B. Had C. Have D. Should Answer: _____

4. _____ it not for a friend's intervention, I would have kept going.

A. Was B. Is C. Were D. Been Answer: _____

5. _____ the situation go badly, it would already have happened to someone else.

A. Should B. Would C. Could D. Will Answer: _____

6. If he keeps working like this, he _____ eventually.
 A. burns out B. will burn out C. burnt out D. had burnt out Answer: _____

C — Gap Fill

Instructions: Complete each sentence with the correct form of the word in brackets.

1. If Rakib _____ (raise) the issue sooner, he wouldn't be this exhausted now.
2. If Nasrin _____ (not / be) so stubborn back then, she would have asked for help earlier.
3. _____ (mention) it three months earlier, Rakib's workload would have been redistributed.
4. Were it not for her friend's intervention, Nasrin _____ (keep) going until she made a serious mistake.
5. Should the presentation _____ (go) badly, Rakib will simply explain what happened.
6. If he _____ (delegate) more tasks last month, his evenings would be freer now.

D — Sentence Transformation

Instructions: Combine each pair of sentences as directed, using the required grammar structure.

1. **Original:** Rakib didn't raise the issue weeks ago. He is exhausted now.

Combine using a mixed conditional (past → present):

If Rakib _____, he wouldn't be this exhausted now.

2. **Original:** Nasrin was stubborn in the past. She didn't ask for help back then.

Combine using a mixed conditional (trait → past result):

If Nasrin _____, she would have asked for help sooner.

3. **Original:** Rakib didn't mention his workload to his manager. It wasn't redistributed.

Combine using inversion with 'Had':

_____, his workload would have been redistributed.

4. **Original:** A friend took Nasrin's laptop away. Because of this, she didn't keep working until she made a mistake.

Combine using inversion with 'Were it not for':

_____, Nasrin would have kept working until she made a mistake.

SECTION 6 | SENTENCE BUILDER — Build Your Own Sentences

Instructions: Use each word or phrase to write one original sentence, following the required grammar structure exactly. Do not copy from the story.

Word / Phrase	Required Grammar Structure	Your Sentence
burnout	Mixed conditional (past condition → present result)	
workload	Mixed conditional (general trait → past result)	
resilience	Inversion with 'Had'	
delegate	Inversion with 'Were it not for'	
unsustainable	Inversion with 'Should'	
toll	Mixed conditional (past condition → present result)	

Word / Phrase	Required Grammar Structure	Your Sentence
capable	Inversion with 'Had'	
reach breaking point	Mixed conditional (general trait → past result)	

SECTION 7 | SHORT WRITING TASK — Think & Write

Instructions: Write 150–180 words. Use at least one mixed conditional and one inverted conditional structure. Write down the main paragraphs only.

Prompt:

Some people believe that employees themselves are mainly responsible for managing their workload and preventing burnout. Others believe that employers and workplace culture bear the greater responsibility. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Writing Space

SECTION 8 | CHARACTER REFLECTION — Character Corner

Instructions: These questions have no single correct answer. Discuss with a partner if possible, then write your own considered response.

1. Nasrin says the information she withheld was “information my manager needed and simply didn't have.” What does this suggest about the difference between suffering silently and communicating a problem clearly?

2. The story ends without a clean fix — the deadlines and culture stay the same. Why might a story about overwork be more honest without a tidy resolution at the end?

3. To what extent is preventing burnout an individual's responsibility (setting personal boundaries), and to what extent is it an organisation's responsibility (workload culture)?

4. Nasrin shares her own past struggle rather than simply giving Rakib advice. What does this suggest about why people are more willing to accept support from someone who has faced something similar?

5. Is saying “I have too much work” a sign of weakness, or a sign of self-awareness? What shapes how such statements are perceived in different workplaces or cultures?

SECTION 9 | HOMEWORK

Level 1	Level 2
Write 6 sentences about workload or balance, each using a mixed conditional or an inverted conditional.	Write a reflective diary/essay entry (150–180 words) titled “A Time I Should Have Asked for Help Sooner.” Use at least 2 mixed conditionals and 1 inversion structure.

Final Reminder: *Recognising an unsustainable workload early is not a weakness — it is the first honest step toward genuine resilience.*